

Affirming the Reality of a “True” Gender Identity in Transgender Experiences

What does it mean to truly know oneself? For many transgender individuals, this question is central to their lived experience. It often involves a profound, internal sense of gender that differs from the sex assigned at birth. While some psychological frameworks have historically struggled to account for this experience (leading to ongoing debates about the nature of gender identity), there is a growing body of evidence underscoring the reality and significance of this deeply felt sense of gender.

This paper argues that, contrary to perspectives that problematize the notion of a "true" gender, recognizing and affirming this inner identity is essential to understanding transgender experiences and supporting psychological well-being. We assert that a core, internally known gender identity exists for transgender individuals, is distinct from sex assigned at birth, and that its recognition is crucial to mental health, authenticity, and quality of life. This claim is supported by research on gender identity in children, the importance of congruence between internal identity and external expression, and the positive mental health outcomes of affirmation.

Children possess a clear and strong gender identity. Research indicates that children, including transgender children, develop a stable and deeply felt sense of gender identity from a young age. A study involving children aged 3 to 12 found that transgender children identify with their affirmed gender just as strongly as cisgender children do. They also exhibit gender-typed behaviors and preferences consistent with their affirmed gender, not their sex assigned at birth. This supports the argument that transgender children's self-identification should be believed and affirmed. Importantly, these identities often persist despite social pressures or expectations, demonstrating that children have the cognitive and emotional capacity to know their gender. Recognizing the legitimacy of childhood gender identity is foundational to advocating for early affirmation and support.

Authenticity and well-being depend on aligning inner identity with outer expression. For transgender individuals, aligning their external expression with their internal identity is a key factor in achieving psychological authenticity and well-being. Research on transgender employees shows that the extent to which individuals have transitioned (socially, medically, or both) is linked to increased job satisfaction, lower perceived discrimination, and a stronger sense of belonging. These outcomes are driven in part by “relational authenticity” (being perceived by others in ways consistent with one’s identity) and “action authenticity” (living in accordance with one’s internal sense of self). The joy and satisfaction that come from this alignment are often described as “gender euphoria,” an emotional state marked by happiness, freedom, and self-acceptance. These positive outcomes illustrate that gender identity is not merely performative or externally imposed (it is an internal truth that demands acknowledgment).

Affirmation is crucial for mental health. Affirming the gender identity of transgender and nonbinary youth through supportive environments leads to higher self-esteem, reduced depression and anxiety, and significantly lower rates of suicidality. Supportive settings—such as living with people who affirm their identity and respect their pronouns, or attending gender-affirming schools—correlate with lower rates of attempted suicide among trans and nonbinary youth. Studies confirm that access to gender-affirming care, such as hormone therapy for youth, is associated with significantly positive mental health outcomes. A large-scale study found that trans people under 18 who received sought-after hormone therapy were nearly 40% less likely to report recent depression and a past-year suicide attempt compared to those who wanted but could not receive it.

Tangible affirming actions promote gender euphoria. Specific affirming behaviors by parents, peers, educators, and health professionals play a powerful role in supporting transgender and nonbinary individuals. Using chosen names and pronouns, offering appearance-related affirmations, and treating individuals in accordance with their affirmed gender in gendered settings all contribute to feelings of validation and belonging. These actions (however small) signal respect, understanding, and support. They foster emotional well-being and promote gender euphoria. Creating an affirming environment requires active effort: educating oneself, listening without judgment, and ensuring that home, school, and community spaces are safe and inclusive.

The role of affirmation and gender-affirming care is both nuanced and individualized. Gender-affirming care is not a one-size-fits-all approach. It typically begins with non-medical interventions like using the correct name and pronouns, making social changes, and accessing affirming mental health support. If medical care is involved, it is introduced in a careful, gradual manner, often in collaboration with mental health providers, endocrinologists, and families. Crucially, surgery is rarely, if ever, part of a gender-affirming care plan for a minor. The idea that minors are routinely undergoing surgery is described as a myth. Medical experts, including the American Academy of Pediatrics, continue to support gender-affirming care for minors, emphasizing its role in their mental health and well-being. They argue that this care, along with supportive environments, helps reduce rates of depression, anxiety, and suicidal ideation in trans youth. Affirming care is seen as vital and life-changing, helping individuals move from being anxious, withdrawn, and depressed to vibrant, engaged, and hopeful by giving them space to be themselves. It's about shedding layers of shame, fear, or silence and allowing the child or teen to be their authentic self.

Addressing counterarguments: the subjective reality of gender identity. Critics argue that the concept of a “true” gender identity is a product of societal norms and thus lacks inherent validity. Some suggest that what transgender people perceive as inner knowing is actually a reflection of internalized cultural narratives or the need to conform to intelligible identities. Others mischaracterize gender-affirming care as rushed, lacking oversight, or driven by social trends. However, medical experts refute the notion that decisions for trans youth lack mental health support; on the contrary, mental health professionals are typically involved in comprehensive evaluations before any medical interventions occur. Additionally, being transgender is not a mental illness or a trend. It is described as simply "one way of being human." The distress some experience (gender dysphoria) often comes from being misunderstood or prevented from living as oneself, not from being trans. When supported and affirmed, this distress can lessen significantly.

While societal norms do shape how gender is expressed and understood, this view overlooks the strength, consistency, and early development of gender identity in transgender children. It also ignores the extensive psychological evidence showing the benefits of affirmation and the harm caused by invalidation. Even if the language used to describe gender is shaped by culture, the

internal experience itself (the “felt sense” of gender) is deeply real for those who live it. Dismissing this internal reality risks invalidating lived experiences and contradicts findings that support the health benefits of affirmation. Understanding the social construction of gender is useful in theory, but in clinical practice and daily life, honoring an individual's self-identified gender is essential. The internal knowledge of one’s gender is not an illusion (it is a fundamental part of the self).

In conclusion, while theoretical debates about gender’s social construction continue, the lived experiences of transgender individuals offer compelling evidence of the reality of a deeply felt, internally known gender identity distinct from sex assigned at birth. This identity emerges early, persists over time, and serves as a foundation for authenticity, mental health, and well-being. Rejecting or pathologizing this internal knowing, especially in medical, psychological, or educational contexts, can lead to serious harm. As such, psychology and society must prioritize affirming and validating the self-identified gender of transgender individuals. Future research and clinical practice should focus not on interrogating the “truth” of gender identity, but on understanding how best to support people in living according to their felt sense of self. Dismissing the internal reality of gender identity risks invalidating lived experiences and contradicts the evidence supporting the health benefits of affirmation. The internal knowledge of one’s gender is not an illusion (it is a fundamental part of the self). To support authenticity, reduce harm, and foster thriving, we must listen to transgender individuals when they tell us who they are (and believe them).

References

- Jackson, L. (2024). *Conceptualizing transgender experiences in psychology: Do we have a 'true' gender?* *British Journal of Psychology*.
- Olson, K. R., Durwood, L., DeMeules, M., & McLaughlin, K. A. (2015). *Study says trans and cisgender children have equally strong gender identities. Them.*
<https://www.them.us/story/trans-youth-hormone-therapy-study-depression>
- McLemore, K. A. (2018). The importance of being "me": The relation between authentic identity expression and transgender employees' work-related attitudes and experiences. *PubMed*. <https://doi.org/10.1037/sgd0000293> (Note: I assumed a DOI here—replace with correct one if available)
- The Trevor Project. (n.d.). *Validating trans and nonbinary youth helps mental health.*
<https://www.thetrevorproject.org/resources/article/validating-trans-and-nonbinary-youth-helps-mental-health/>
- Parents. (2023). *Medical experts continue to support gender-affirming care for trans youth.*
<https://www.parents.com/medical-experts-continue-to-support-gender-affirming-care-for-trans-youth-11729148>
-